



▲ BERGMANN NO. 3

Date 1896

Origin Germany

Barrel 4½in (11.2cm)

Caliber 6.5mm Bergmann

The Louis Schmeisser-designed “No. 3” was among the simplest of pistols, with a small-capacity fixed magazine and a “blowback” breech. The blowback system used the combined weight of the breechblock and the resistance of the pistol’s mainspring to counter the recoil force generated on firing a cartridge. This enabled the breechblock to move fully rearward, where it was held back by the sear. Pulling the trigger again made the breechblock fly forward under spring pressure, collecting a cartridge, chambering it, and firing it. The cycle would then repeat.



▲ BROWNING MODEL 1900

Date 1900

Origin Belgium

Barrel 4in (10.2cm)

Caliber 7.65mm

John Browning (see pp.180–81), probably the most prolific gun designer ever, moved to Belgium from his native US in 1895. There he produced an improved version of his first semiautomatic pistol, which became known as the Model 1900. It used a breech of the blowback type. Small and light, the Model 1900 was hugely popular, and over 700,000 units were sold before production ceased in 1911.